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By Martina Sapio · Aug 27, 2026, 8:52 PM · [View in your browser](#)

Greece has signed a joint EU paper setting common red lines on the International Maritime Organization's Net-Zero Framework, despite vocal opposition from the country's powerful shipping industry and months of signaling support for countries seeking to weaken the rules.

The nonpublic paper is dated July 20 and signed by all 27 EU member countries. The document, obtained by POLITICO, lays out the EU's common opening position for negotiations on the IMO's proposed Net-Zero Framework in London from Sept. 1-4.

The framework would require ships to meet progressively stricter fuel-emissions targets, with vessels that exceed them paying into a dedicated fund while cleaner ships earn tradable credits and potentially financial rewards.

At the last round of talks in November, Greece and Cyprus abstained rather than back the EU position, which then supported the framework unchanged. Since then, Brussels has softened its negotiating mandate while still backing a 2050 deadline for net-zero emissions, while Athens has publicly aligned itself more closely with opponents of the EU-backed approach.

These countries, including the United States, Saudi Arabia, Russia, Argentina, Panama and Liberia, are pushing for a looser system tied more closely to the availability and cost of cleaner fuels rather than fixed targets and a central carbon-pricing mechanism.

But now, Athens appears set to negotiate as part of a united EU bloc in London. That puts it at odds with its own shipping industry, which represents about 60 percent of the EU fleet and roughly one-fifth of the global fleet, and has been among the framework's most outspoken critics.

In an Aug. 24 statement, Union of Greek Shipowners President Melina Travlos called the draft Net-Zero Framework "clearly not the solution." She warned that the negotiations revealed "significant weaknesses" in the proposal, which does not adequately account for the cost, availability and scalability of the fuels the transition would require.

They say the original IMO proposal would force the industry to move faster than clean fuels can become affordable and widely available. Greek shipowners back a rival plan from Panama and Liberia instead, which would adjust targets to the fuels and technologies available on the market.

One of the central disputes is also which fuels ships will be allowed to use under the new rules. Greece, the United States and Saudi Arabia, among others, want liquefied natural gas to remain part of the

transition.

Speaking at the Posidonia shipping summit in June, Prime Minister Kyriakos Mitsotakis argued that natural gas should remain a reliable transitional fuel while cleaner alternatives are developed, insisting that “nothing can be done for European shipping without us.”

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